THE STARTUP SCOOP

STARTUP WINS YOU SHOULD KNOW ABOUT

GridLink is on a roll!

GridLink became the first IIT team to compete in the Rice Business Plan Competition after taking first place at Pitch Tank, and they're only just getting started. The group secured a $300K investment from a local venture capitalist after joining Techstars Chicago. Big decisions equal a bigger future.

Biagon Breaks Ground in Biotech!

Biagon is growing quickly after winning $15K and placing second at Pitch Tank. Their goal to transform pharmaceutical research is being fueled by the $270K ART award that their AI-driven drug discovery technology recently received.

HawkBot Takes Flight!

Nitin Murali's HawkBot, which was introduced on IIT's Coursera website, is transforming education through AI. Win a bonus? He got an internship at Aeropay as a Machine Learning Product Manager after a fortuitous encounter at Chicago Startup Week.

Florena & Co. Blossoms!

Thea Paskaleva's Florena & Co. was born out of a passionate moment and is attracting attention with floral creations that are both beautiful and intimate. From gifts on campus to significant life events, this startup is thriving.

Funzy Gets Acquired!

What began as fun educational software has become a success story in the ed-tech industry. Siddhartha Upase established Funzy, which App Smartz purchased in June 2024, demonstrating that effect and enjoyment go hand in hand.

Startup Trend Spotlight: Founder-Market Fit is the New MVP

We're witnessing a change at Kaplan Startup Studio: mentors and investors are seeking founder-market fit rather than just product-market fit. Put otherwise, why did you come up with this idea?

The businesses gaining traction are run by teams whose lived experiences inform their ideas, whether it's a student addressing campus problems (like HawkBot) or a biotech founder with lab experience (like Biagon). Ask yourself, "What makes me uniquely qualified to solve this?" before you start building.

SAVE THE DATE

- **Intro to Customer Discovery:**
  Thursday, July 24th
  12–1 PM
  Kaplan Institute
  Discover how to test your idea on actual users before wasting time creating something that doesn't work.
- **Pitch Tank Bootcamp:**
  Thursday, Aug 22nd
  12–1 PM
  Kaplan Institute
  This session is your startup's gym, whether you're getting ready to pitch or you just want expert input.
- **Chicagoland Founders Mixer:**
  Monday, Sept 1st
  12–1 PM
  Kaplan Institute
  Get to know the best VCs, founders, and student innovators in Chicago. This is your opportunity to make connections outside of campus.

!!ATTENTION!!